

ETHIOPIAN HIGHLANDS

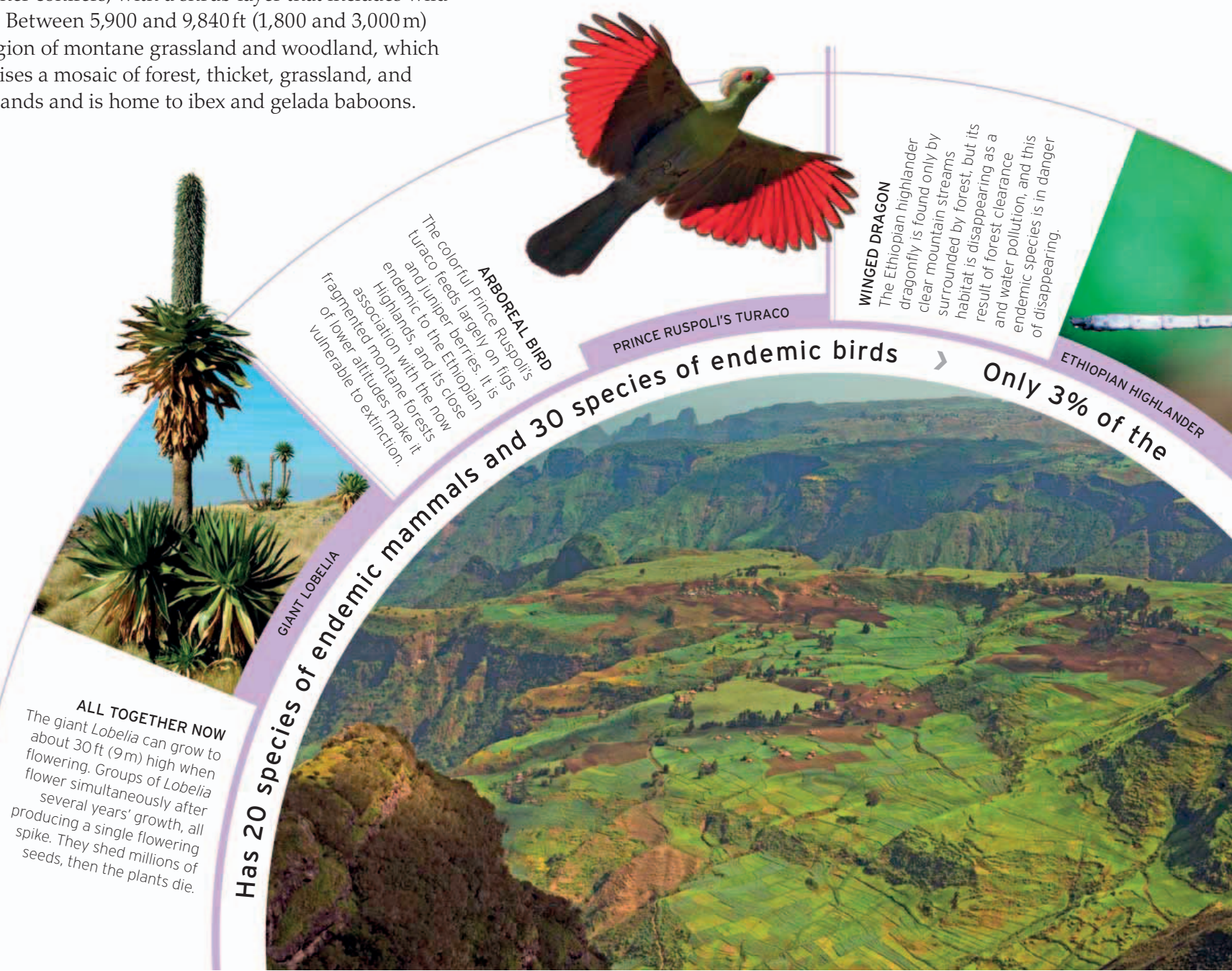
A hotspot of unique species in the roof of Africa

The largest area of land above 4,920 ft (1,500 m) in the whole of Africa, the Ethiopian Highlands rise to about nearly 15,000 ft (4,550 m) in the northeast of the continent. The region contains the Semien Mountains in the northwest and the Bale Mountains in the southeast, with part of the Great Rift Valley separating the two.

Loss of habitat

The area contains three distinct regions, differentiated by altitude. Up to about 5,900 ft (1,800 m) is dense montane forest, where the natural vegetation is dominated by evergreen trees, including myrrh, acacia, and juniper, and other conifers, with a shrub layer that includes wild coffee. Between 5,900 and 9,840 ft (1,800 and 3,000 m) is a region of montane grassland and woodland, which comprises a mosaic of forest, thicket, grassland, and brushlands and is home to ibex and gelada baboons.

Above the treeline, from 9,840 ft (3,000 m) upward, is montane moorland. The natural vegetation of this area is dominated by alpine shrubs and herbs. The densest collection of endemic wildlife, including mountain nyala and the world's rarest dog species, the Ethiopian wolf, is found here. All three regions have been severely impacted by human population increase and activities, mainly farming and unsustainable use of natural resources. As a result, an estimated 97 percent of the area's original habitat has been lost. Therefore, many of the plants and animals are being intensively studied and protected.



ARBOREAL BIRD
The colorful Prince Ruspoli's turaco feeds largely on figs and juniper berries. It is endemic to the Ethiopian Highlands, and its close association with the now fragmented montane forests of lower altitudes make it vulnerable to extinction.

PRINCE RUSPOLI'S TURACO

WINGED DRAGON
The Ethiopian highlander dragonfly is found only by clear mountain streams surrounded by forest, but its habitat is disappearing as a result of forest clearance and water pollution, and this endemic species is in danger of disappearing.

ETHIOPIAN HIGHLANDER

Giant Lobelia
Has 20 species of endemic mammals and 30 species of endemic birds

ALL TOGETHER NOW
The giant Lobelia can grow to about 30 ft (9 m) high when flowering. Groups of Lobelia flower simultaneously after several years' growth, all producing a single flowering spike. They shed millions of seeds, then the plants die.

Only 3% of the